MONTHLY UPDATE

Zambia: monthly update, September – October 2026

Edition of 2026-10-12 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

> *Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.*

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

The finance minister put the national portal at 572 services across 52 providers and about K9.8 billion collected since 2019, and said the 2027-2029 budget call circular names the service bus and payment gateway as the centralised revenue-collection system. Consultations opened on a review of the Electronic Communications and Transactions Act. Police made a third arrest inside ten days for online speech under the cyber crimes law, and a former deputy minister defended the invalidation of government critics' identity documents. A bank launched direct renminbi settlement in Lusaka on 23 September.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The second term opened on a new blueprint. The state ICT institute endorsed the Grow Zambia Agenda 2026-2031 for its eight digital-infrastructure targets and said it is building a real-time Cabinet dashboard to monitor it; the targets themselves are not published.

The technology and youth ministries are developing a framework for local content creators to earn from digital platforms, engaging Meta, TikTok and Google and compiling a national database of creators, after the President made it a priority at the opening of the 14th National Assembly.

Legislation and regulation

The regulator removed an operator from the market. It revoked a network and service licence with effect from 14 September, citing persistent failures to meet regulatory, operational and financial obligations, after assessing the operator's representations.

The technology ministry opened consultations on amending the Electronic Communications and Transactions Act No. 4 of 2021, with a Lusaka Province meeting reported on 30 September: the amendment, approved in principle by Cabinet in September 2025, would end the tie between licensing certification and time-stamping providers and critical-information-infrastructure designation, and strengthen the national public key infrastructure under ZICTA. No draft text is published.

Data protection

The technology ministry's permanent secretary said the country is implementing a national child online protection strategy for 2025 to 2029.

Standards

The trust layer under the interoperability standards was stood up. The communications regulator operationalised the National Digital Trust Anchor in its capacity as national root certification authority, the framework issuing and verifying digital certificates and signatures establishing the identity of people and organisations, on the legal base of the electronic communications and transactions statute. No certificate count, subordinate-authority list, accreditation route or fee schedule is published, and the launch reaches the repository through a news report rather than the regulator's own notice — which for a root certification authority is the one thing a relying party would want to be able to check. The national public key infrastructure was launched with a named security vendor, its master cryptographic keys generated under independently audited conditions, held offline and split among multiple custodians so that no single entity has unilateral control.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The criminal route for online speech was used. A Lusaka magistrate convicted a vlogger on 11 September under section 54 of the Cyber Security and Cyber Crimes Act 2021 for forwarding a WhatsApp screenshot about a presidential aide.

A second case followed the next day: a tailor in Mansa was arrested under the cyber crimes statute over a TikTok video insulting the president.

The section 54 case ended in custody: the vlogger was sentenced to nine months on 15 September for forwarding a screenshot.

Finance

New investments

The regional programme's half-year report records the acceleration project's unit fully staffed and a second early market engagement on 22 April 2026 for 300 cell towers, 2,000 km of fibre and connectivity for 500 public institutions.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

A second account of the same period puts internet subscriptions at 14.7m in 2025 against 10.4m in 2021, and mobile population coverage at 95% over 2022 to 2025. The coverage figure is government-reported and does not reconcile with the ministry's own separate claim for the same period — a reminder that every coverage number here comes from the same source as the target it is measured against.

A mobile operator is acquiring about 1,300 km of fibre from a related company in the same group for K324.9 million, independently valued and classed as a small related-party transaction (21 September). It moves existing fibre between two companies of one group; it adds no route.

DPI

Data Exchange

A government delegation completed a two-week learning mission to India on 7 September 2026 under UNDP's digital public infrastructure accelerator. Zambia and four neighbours adopted a roadmap for customs-to-customs data exchange at a meeting in Pretoria ending 26 August, building on links it already runs with Malawi and Zimbabwe. Bids for the redesign of the Government Service Bus were evaluated and under the lender's review at June 2026.

Digital Identity and CRVS

A former deputy minister defended, on 19 September 2026, the invalidation of the national identity documents of individuals she accuses of abusing cyberspace against the President. How many people are affected and under what legal process is unstated, and no government statement of the measure is on file. Re-evaluation of the bids to deploy and integrate the identity and civil registration modules was complete at June 2026 and awaiting the lender's review; no award is on record.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The account base under the inclusion figure was stated: 14.7m registered mobile money accounts in 2024 on the monetary fund's financial access survey, of which 77% hold a balance, against one adult in five holding any account at all in 2011, with the central bank phasing out cheque clearing behind it. Registered accounts are not people, and the balance share is the only measure of activity the repository holds against the count.

Trade with China gained a direct channel: a commercial bank launched renminbi settlement over China's Cross-Border Interbank Payment System in Lusaka on 23 September, with the commerce ministry presenting it as a cut in conversion and intermediary costs. No volume, fee or participant count was published.

Registries

One district office in Muchinga Province reported registering more than 3,000 children under five in the four months to September 2026, working with the health ministry's environmental health departments.

Sectoral management information systems

Beneficiary checks for the Keeping Girls in School programme moved from paper forms to a tablet application on which each girl is captured and signs for herself, replacing forms others could sign on her behalf; 25 guidance teachers in Lavushimanda District were trained on it. No national count of schools on the application is published.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The office platform was ordered across the whole of government. The Secretary to the Cabinet directed every government institution to adopt the Smart Office Platform and instructed the Smart Zambia Institute to report to his office by the end of October 2026 on the onboarding of ministries, provinces, spending agencies, state-owned enterprises and other public institutions, the direction given at the handover of the system to the airports corporation at Chongwe. It is a direction with a reporting deadline rather than a measured rollout: the repository has carried the platform as a health-ministry pilot since 2025 and holds no count of institutions onboarded.

The office system moved beyond ministries for the first time. The airports corporation became the first state-owned enterprise onboarded, the system commissioned and handed over by the Secretary to the Cabinet, with a further 406 staff to be trained across its stations by the end of November — the same directive that told every government institution to adopt it now reaching the commercial arm of the state.

The Public Service Management Division said on 23 September that a digital platform for the public service funeral scheme, run with an insurer, will roll out in the first week of October, letting members update their details, register beneficiaries and track claims by phone or computer instead of on paper. The meteorological department and the agriculture ministry are building a national digital climate advisory service that sends farmers localised forecast and agronomic advice by text message.

Digitalisation

Rural digital data capture

A larger programme followed on 15 September: 70 schools are to be connected by satellite with solar power over three years, free for the first year and sold at affordable rates after.

Technology

AI

UNDP published lessons on 17 September from AI compute it has installed with public institutions in six countries, Zambia among them. The lead use here is AI analysis of critical-minerals data with the mines ministry and the environmental agency, with data access still to be confirmed.

The technology ministry is piloting Njila.ai, an artificial-intelligence career-guidance platform in the technical and vocational training system under a World Bank-backed skills project, expected to reach more than 17,000 young people.

Inclusion

Access to services

At home, one fibre operator cut its entry price to K300 a month for 6 Mbps, an operator's own announcement rather than a market measure. The operator launched a self-care application and a short-code digital financial service; no user figure is published.

Digital divides

A three-year programme run by the presidential delivery unit with private partners will connect an initial 70 public schools by satellite, adding solar power where schools are off the grid. No cost or school list is stated.

Data

Open data

The finance ministry, the statistics agency and UNICEF launched a national research repository bringing research and evaluations held in hard copy or scattered across institutions onto one platform. No holdings count or licence terms are stated.

Use of satellite data

A Zambian firm founded in 2023, Mytochondria, uses satellite imagery and artificial intelligence to measure soil moisture, temperature and nutrients and advise farmers on irrigation and fertiliser, and was placed second in the African Union's startup contest; no user count is published.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The health minister said the health memorandum with the United States was finalised and due for signature after a specimen-sharing clause was removed. Zambia and the United States signed the five-year health financing memorandum, put at US$2.49bn, after the specimen-sharing and patient-data clauses were removed. A Zambian outlet reported a data sharing agreement signed beside the health memorandum, limited to aggregated and de-identified programme data.

India activities

India enters the record as a destination rather than a donor. Officials from the digital and ICT sector and line ministries joined delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda and Sierra Leone and the African Union Commission on a south-south learning mission hosted by the United Nations Development Programme, studying India's digital public infrastructure and the institutions that built it; the state government of Karnataka received them in Bengaluru on 1 September. No agreement, financing, technology transfer or follow-on commitment is named on either side.

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